PROFESSIONAL LINKEDIN CHECKLIST

Your LinkedIn profile is your online professional brand: It is often the first place employers, recruiters and professional contacts will look to understand who you are.

Explore careers and understand the jobs market: Research roles, organisations and career paths, follow developments in sectors that interest you and learn from people already working in those areas.

Build your network and create opportunities: Connect with alumni, employers and professionals, comment on relevant posts and build relationships that can lead to information, introductions and opportunities.

1 Profile Photo

Your profile photo is one of the first things people notice and should help you look professional, approachable and easy to recognise

- [ ] Have you included a recent head and shoulders photo of yourself? Aim for your face to fill around 60% of the frame.
- [ ] Are you smiling naturally, looking at the camera and dressed professionally?
- [ ] Is the background simple and non-distracting?
- [ ] Use a photo of you alone. If you want to include a team or group image, use it as your background photo instead.

! Your profile photo should look like you on a good day at work, not a passport photo or a cropped social photo. NCI offers professional LinkedIn headshots free of charge each week.

2 Background Photo

Your background image is an opportunity to reinforce your professional brand, interests and career direction. Use it to show something about your professional interests, career area or the type of work you want to move into.

- [ ] The image could show a relevant workplace or project, a team or event, the NCI campus or IFSC area, or an example of your work such as a design, dashboard or campaign.

3 Personalised URL

A personalised LinkedIn URL makes your profile easier to find and share. It gives you a clean, professional link to use on your CV, applications, cover letters and email signature.

- [ ] Change the default URL so it uses your name rather than a long string of numbers and letters after your name.
- [ ] Keep it short, clear and professional. If your name is gone add a simple variation e.g https://www.linkedin.com/in/carolinekennedycareers/
- [ ] Add your personalised LinkedIn URL to your CV, applications and email signature.

4 Name Pronunciation

Adding your name pronunciation can help new contacts address you correctly before an interview, networking event or first meeting.

- [ ] Add a short recording of your preferred professional name pronunciation.
- [ ] LinkedIn currently allows a recording of up to 10 seconds through the mobile app.

5 Headline

Your headline is one of the most visible parts of your LinkedIn profile, appearing in search results, comments and connection requests. Use it to show who you are and give people a reason to view the rest of your profile.

- [ ] Avoid using only “Student at NCI” or your current job title. On their own, these tell an employer very little about what you can offer or the type of opportunity you are looking for.
- [ ] Include at least two or three of the following in your headline:
  - Current role or degree
  - Area of study
  - Key skills or technical expertise
  - Relevant internship or experience
  - Relevant achievement or qualification
  - Career goal or target role
  - Industry or sector of interest
- [ ] A useful structure is: Current status | Relevant experience or skills | Key differentiator | Target opportunity

★ Sample Headlines

- MSc Finance Student | Equity Research & Mutual Fund Analysis Experience | Seeking xxx | Graduating September 2027
- 2:1 Accountancy Finalist | 12 Months’ Audit Experience with a Top 20 Firm | CAP 1 exempt | Seeking Graduate Audit Opportunity | September 2027
- 1:1 Marketing Student @NCIRL | Experienced in Google Analytics & Adobe Creative Suite | Seeking Digital Marketing Opportunity | Available June 2027

6 Contact Information

Your contact information should make it easy for an employer or professional contact to reach you and access relevant examples of your work.

- [ ] Include a professional email address that you check regularly.
- [ ] Add relevant links such as a portfolio, personal website, GitHub profile or professional social media account where appropriate.
- [ ] There is no need to include personal information such as your phone number or date of birth.

7 About

Use your About section to bring your profile to life. Go beyond listing qualifications and experience: explain what you are good at, what has shaped your interests, the value you can offer and where you want to go next. Only the opening few lines are visible before someone has to click “see more”, so those first lines need to be give them a reason to keep reading.

- [ ] Write in first person and keep the tone professional but natural. Avoid generic, over-polished language that sounds AI-generated or could have been written by anyone.

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7 About

- [ ] Start with a strong opening that says what you are studying, where you are studying and the type of role or career area you are targeting.
- [ ] Back up what you say with evidence such as relevant experience, projects, achievements, technical skills, certifications or responsibilities.
- [ ] Avoid vague phrases such as “passionate about”, “hardworking” or “motivated” unless you support them with evidence.
- [ ] Include relevant skills, tools, job titles and industry terms naturally throughout the section.
- [ ] Finish with a clear next step, such as the type of graduate role, internship, placement or sector you are looking for.

Quick Check
Could another student copy and paste your About section and it still make sense? If yes, it is probably too generic.

8 Featured Section

The Featured section gives visitors a snapshot of portfolios, work samples, achievements and skills. It is an opportunity to show employers evidence of what you can do and what you have achieved.

- [ ] You can include projects, portfolios, presentations, awards, certifications, reports, dashboards, GitHub work, campaign examples, articles, videos or other samples of your work.
- [ ] Prioritise items that are relevant to the type of role you are targeting.

9 Education

Your Education section should make it easy for employers to understand what you are studying, where you are studying and when you expect to graduate.

- [ ] Include your full degree title, institution and expected graduation date. Add relevant modules, projects, dissertation/research topics or academic achievements where they support the role you are targeting.
- [ ] Include your current grade or classification if strong and relevant (1st, 2:1)
- [ ] Include societies, competitions, leadership roles or other relevant college involvement.
- [ ] Add media where helpful, for example a project, presentation, research paper or portfolio item.

10 Certifications & Licences

Add relevant certifications, professional exams and licences that strengthen your profile.

- [ ] Examples could include Google Analytics/Ads, Microsoft, AWS or Cisco certifications, Bloomberg Market Concepts, professional exam progress, First Aid or a Full Driving Licence.

11 Work Experience

Your Work Experience section should show what you contributed, the level of responsibility you had and the value you added, not simply list your duties.

- [ ] Start each role with enough context for the reader to understand the organisation, team, client group or scale of the work.
- [ ] Do not copy and paste your job description or list routine duties. Focus instead on what you achieved, improved, delivered or contributed to.
- [ ] Where possible, show scope and outcomes, for example volumes handled, customers supported, projects completed, time saved, processes improved, revenue supported or problems resolved.
- [ ] Highlight the parts of each role that are most relevant to the type of opportunity you are now targeting.
- [ ] Include relevant systems, software, tools and technical skills naturally within the description.
- [ ] Avoid vague phrases such as “responsible for”, “worked as part of a team” or “helped with various tasks” unless you explain what you actually did and what resulted from it.

Quick Check
Does each role show an employer what you did, the scale of it and the value you added?

12 Skills

Your Skills section should reinforce the type of work you want to move into and make your key technical and role-specific skills easy for employers to identify.

- [ ] Prioritise skills that appear regularly in the roles you are targeting.
- [ ] Include relevant technical skills, software, tools, languages and specialist knowledge.

13 Connections & Networking

- [ ] **Who to connect with:** Connect with classmates, lecturers, alumni, colleagues, employers and people you meet through events, placements and professional activity.
- [ ] **Commenting on Posts:** If an employer shares an event or industry update that is relevant to you, you could add a thoughtful comment. A well-written comment can help you become more visible, demonstrate interest and put your name and LinkedIn headline in front of the employer and their wider network.
- [ ] **Use the Alumni tool to identify alumni to follow and connect with:** Look at where NCI graduates work and the roles they hold. Use this to research possible career paths, identify employers you may not have considered and find alumni you could follow or approach for an informed conversation.
- [ ] **Protect your Professional Brand:** Be conscious that what you post and comment on contributes to how you are perceived professionally. Avoid negative posts about recruitment processes or the jobs market. Comments such as “I have applied everywhere and no one is hiring” can undermine the professional impression you are trying to build.Use your activity to show interest, effort and development. Share or comment on events you have attended, courses you have completed, projects or hackathons you have taken part in etc.